

Reading Response:

Governance of the Black Experience on Reddit: r/BlackPeopleTwitter as a Case Study in Supporting Sense of Virtual Community for Black Users – Smith et. al

Summary: Main Takeaways? The paper aims to understand the needs and Sense of Virtual Community of Black users on Reddit to serve them more effectively, trying to move away from "damage-centered" and "color-blind" research that typically focuses on negativity or microaggressions in communities of color. The authors unsteady try to highlight positive interaction and find that r/BlackPeopleTwitter is a place where Black culture thrives. Specifically, they found that Black users report higher SOVC and membership, while white and non-Black POC users often feel like guests who benefit from a glimpse into Black culture. Still, overall, users have positive engagement with this subreddit regardless of race, confirming r/BPT as a positive celebration of black culture. **Strengths/weaknesses and/or limitations:** A key strength is the researchers' inclusion of a positionality statement and their adoption of "racial consciousness" rather than color-blindness, which, to me, seems to be the "higher ground" position many researchers mistakenly take when dealing with race. They were quite clear that they were focused specifically on how their research helps them understand and cultivate the black experience online. They focus on r/BlackPeopleTwitter as a space where Black identity is continuously redefined and celebrated. Still, a limitation is the "flattening" or erasure of non-Black POC identities into a single category, which the authors admit is imperfect but was necessary to serve their target population; my group project had to do a similar thing with age groups to ensure we were accurately serving the age range we set out to cater to. **Questions:** I am curious about the "contentious" nature of limited participation. Specifically, which groups find it most problematic, as even some Black users expressed concerns about exclusion. I also wonder about digital verification; does creating separate apps or spaces for Black people create silos and defeat the purpose of having safe spaces on broader public platforms like Reddit? Furthermore, verification techniques like "skill-testing questions" (e.g., the grits question) risk excluding those with different cultural upbringings, raising questions about how "Black authenticity" is defined and if it inadvertently alienates authentic members. I bring up this last point because I've had people confide in me about not feeling "Indian enough" within certain South Asian affinity groups, both in person and online.

Reaction: interesting/thought-provoking: I found the concept of BPT as the "front page of Black Twitter" particularly interesting; it functions as a "best of" aggregator where content is curated and vetted. This feels particularly sustainable and unique as a platform to relate to Black culture; the analogy that came to mind in my head is thrifting. I like to thrift or buy secondhand because I know that a piece of clothing was pre-loved. Knowing that someone else had an item of clothing in their wardrobe feels like that piece has been vetted (with exceptions for the truly ugly pieces in some stores). Also, the reliance on anonymity feels paradoxical—it serves as a safe space where users can be authentic, yet they may feel they can only avoid judgment if they are hidden. It is also notable that non-Black POC are drawn to BPT to engage with content that

isn't overwhelmingly white (a huge population on Reddit). **Applications:** This inspires me to think about how my future design choices should focus on consciously supporting certain racial identities, rather than being race agnostic or colorblind. Furthermore, I think the conversation around verification is a tricky one and ought to be further studied. Technology should navigate the complexities of verification carefully to ensure that we don't too rigidly define authentic behavior or box the diversities within a certain racial group into specific behaviors or tendencies. Essentially, we should aim for safety through verification without enforcing a monolithic definition of identity.